

Culture

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Chapter 3 · Based on Richard T. Schaefer, *Sociology: A Brief Introduction*, 14th ed.

What Is Culture?

Culture is learned so early and shared so completely that it feels like nature.
Sociology makes it visible again.

Fiji's Body Ideal Changed After Television Arrived

- In Fiji, a robust, nicely rounded body was traditionally the ideal for men and women
- “You’ve gained weight” was a compliment; “Your legs are skinny” was an insult
- Cable television arrived in **1995**, carrying programs made elsewhere
- For the first time, eating disorders appeared among young people, especially young women (A. Becker 2007)

Studying culture in places like Fiji sheds light on our own society as well.

Culture Is Learned, Shared, and Transmitted

- **Culture** — the totality of learned, socially transmitted customs, knowledge, material objects, and behavior
- It includes the ideas, values, and artifacts of groups of people
- Not only the fine arts: a Rembrandt portrait **and** graffiti, slang words, ice-cream cones, and rock music are all culture

A Society Shares a Territory and a Common Culture

- **Society** — a fairly large number of people who live in the same territory, are relatively independent of people outside their area, and participate in a common culture
- A society is the largest form of human group
- A city, however populous, is not automatically a society; it depends on wider political, economic, and cultural institutions
- Members learn the culture and transmit it from one generation to the next

Culture Works as a Tool Kit of Taken-for-Granted Assumptions

- Culture supplies a **tool kit** of habits, skills, and styles for acquiring knowledge, dealing with kin, and entering the job market
- Without social transmission, each generation would have to reinvent communication, “not to mention the wheel”
- You assume theaters will have seats, physicians will keep your information confidential, and a red light means you should stop.

Murdock's Cultural Universals

- **Cultural universals** — common practices and beliefs that all societies have developed
- Many are adaptations to essential human needs such as food, shelter, and clothing
- George Murdock (1945) listed athletic sports, cooking, dancing, visiting, personal names, marriage, medicine, religious ritual, funeral ceremonies, and trade
- The practice is universal; its **expression** varies between cultures and changes over time

Marriage exists everywhere. One society lets members choose their partners; another encourages marriages arranged by parents.

Ethnocentrism Judges Other Cultures by Our Own Standards

- **Ethnocentrism** — the tendency to assume that one's own culture and way of life represent the norm or are superior to all others (William Graham Sumner 1906)
- Everyday language carries it: *underdeveloped*, *backward*, *primitive*; what “we” believe is religion, what “they” believe is superstition
- Cultures who treat cattle as food may look down on India's Hindu culture, which views the cow as sacred
- People from Kuwait may be surprised by the disrespect U.S. children show their parents

Our view of the world is dramatically influenced by the society in which we were raised.

Cultural Relativism Views Behavior from Inside Its Own Culture

- **Cultural relativism** — viewing people's behavior from the perspective of their own culture
- It places a priority on understanding other cultures rather than dismissing them as "strange" or "exotic"
- It employs the **value neutrality** Max Weber saw as essential to scientific study
- It does **not** require accepting every cultural variation; it requires a serious and unbiased effort to evaluate norms, values, and customs in their own context

Eating with Your Hands Can Follow Strict Etiquette

- An outsider may treat cutlery as the standard and eating with one's hands as a lack of manners
- Across parts of South Asia, the Middle East, and Africa, eating with the hands has learned rules about **which hand**, which foods, sharing, and cleanliness
- The method is not “no etiquette.” It is a **different system of etiquette** (Mann et al. 2011)

Cultural relativism asks what a practice means to the people who know its rules.

Sociobiology Traces Social Behavior to Genetics

- **Sociobiology** — the systematic study of how biology affects human social behavior
- Sociobiologists assert that many cultural traits, such as the near-universal expectation that women nurture and men provide, are rooted in genetic makeup rather than learned

In its extreme form, sociobiology suggests that all behavior results from genetic or biological factors and that social interaction plays no role.

Most Sociologists Say Behavior, Not Genes, Defines Social Reality

- Sociobiologists study groups that share characteristics, not “why Fred is more aggressive than Jim”
- They stress the genetic heritage all humans share and show little interest in alleged differences between racial groups or nationalities
- Genetic markers linked to behavior are **not deterministic**: family cohesiveness and peer groups can override them (Guo et al. 2008)
- Most social scientists accept a biological basis for social behavior, yet hold that people’s **behavior**, not their genetic structure, defines social reality

Conflict theorists fear that sociobiology could be used to argue against helping disadvantaged people, such as struggling schoolchildren.

Thinking Critically: Three Universals from a Functionalist View

Choose three items from Murdock's list of cultural universals.

- Why is each practice found in every culture?
- What function does it serve for the society?
- How does its **expression** here differ from its expression in a culture you know from travel, family, or media?

Murdock's list: athletic sports · cooking · dancing · visiting · personal names · marriage · medicine · religious ritual · funeral ceremonies · trade

The Role of Language

Language does more than describe reality. It also shapes what a culture notices, values, and passes on.

Language Is a Component of Cultural Capital

- Language is one of the major elements of culture
- **Cultural capital** (from Bourdieu, chapter 1 lecture): noneconomic assets such as family background and past educational investments, reflected in a person's knowledge of language and the arts
- A shared language simplifies daily exchange: you ask for a *flashlight* without drawing one; in England you would ask for a *torch*
- One term can still carry several meanings: a *mouse* may be an animal or a computer device; context tells you which one

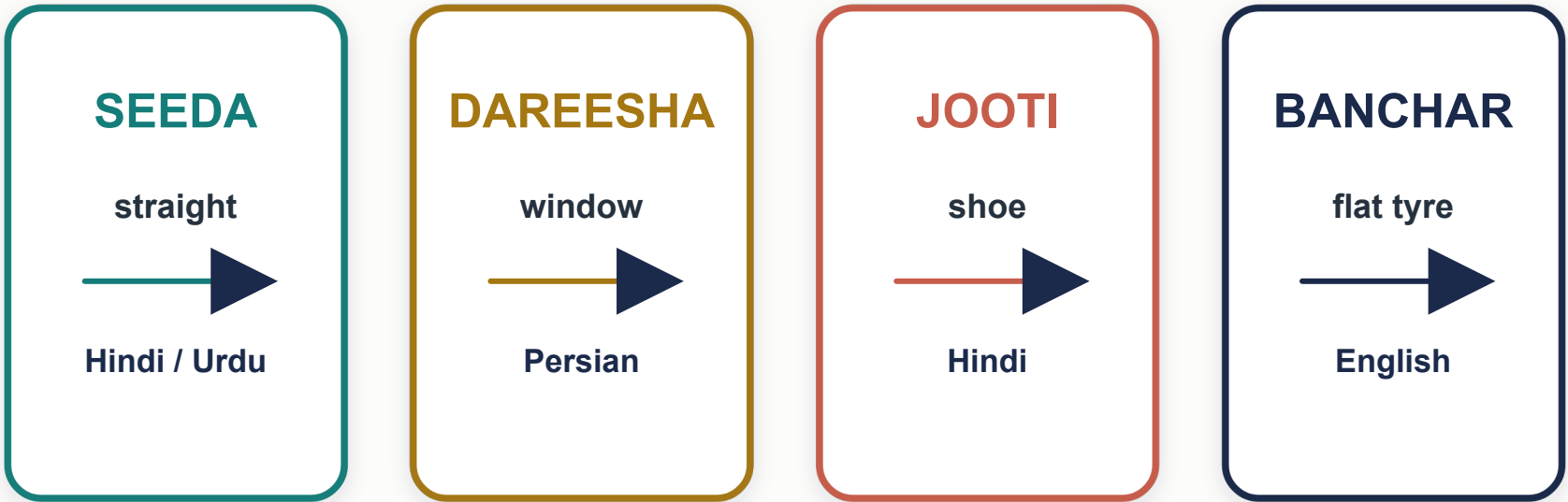
How Many Languages Are Hiding Inside Kuwaiti Arabic?

سيدا • وانيت • دريشة • جوتي • بنچر

Guess the source language of each word.

Kuwaiti Arabic Records Trade, Migration, and New Technology

HOW MANY LANGUAGES ARE HIDING INSIDE KUWAITI ARABIC?



Trade and migration leave traces in ordinary speech.

Seven Thousand Languages Carry Seven Thousand Cultures

- About **7,000 languages** are spoken today, many more than the number of countries
- English makes extensive use of war vocabulary: “conquering” space, “waging war” on drugs, a “killing” on the stock market, “bombing” an exam
- The Sami people of northern Norway and Sweden have a rich diversity of terms for snow, ice, and reindeer (Haviland et al. 2015; Magga 2006)
- An outside observer could gauge what matters to a culture from the words it has multiplied

Language Is the Foundation of Every Culture

- **Language** — an abstract system of word meanings and symbols for all aspects of culture
- It includes speech, written characters, numerals, symbols, and nonverbal gestures and expressions
- Because language is the foundation of every culture, the ability to speak other languages is crucial to intercultural relations
- During the Cold War, the U.S. government built special Russian-language schools for diplomats and military advisers
- Hospitals, airlines, schools, diplomacy, and international business all depend on people who can move accurately between languages

Language Shapes Reality, Not Only Describes It

- Most people from other cultures cannot make the Sami distinctions about snow and ice, so they are less likely to **notice** them
- Terms such as *mailman*, *policeman*, and *fireman* reflect, though do not determine, who is imagined in those jobs
- Language communicates a culture's most important norms, values, and sanctions, which is why the decline of an old language is so sensitive

Interaction Increasingly Takes Place by Text

- More interaction now happens through mobile devices than face to face
- Social scientists are beginning to study how texting language varies across societies and cultures

How does the language you text in differ from the language you speak, and from the language you write for a professor?

Platforms Now Help Shape the Words People Use

- **Algospeak** — altered or substitute words created partly to avoid automated content moderation
- Examples include *unalive* for *die* or *kill*, and creative spellings that remain legible to people while trying to evade a filter
- Users respond to what they **believe** an algorithm will suppress; the rules are opaque, so the language keeps changing
- A platform is not only a channel for culture. Its technical rules can become a pressure on vocabulary (Steen et al. 2023)

Nonverbal Communication Is Learned, Not Inborn

- **Nonverbal communication** — the use of gestures, facial expressions, and other visual images to communicate
- Folding your arms in a meeting, hugging a friend in tears, high-fiving a teammate
- We learn these expressions from people who share our culture, including the basic expressions of happiness and sadness (Hall et al. 2019)
- Gently shaking an Arabic coffee cup tells the server, “I am finished”; returning it without the shake can invite another pour (UNESCO; KUNA 2008)
- In many Arab and Asian settings, deliberately showing someone the sole of a shoe can feel insulting; elsewhere it may pass unnoticed

Specialized Communities Build Nonverbal Vocabularies

- In noisy open-outcry trading pits, traders used hand positions to communicate **buy or sell, price, quantity, and order type**
- Palms toward the body meant **buy**; palms facing away meant **sell**
- Similar gestures could mean different things in different trading pits—another reminder that symbols require a shared code
- Watch: “Wall Street Trading Floor Hand Signals” (YancyFX)

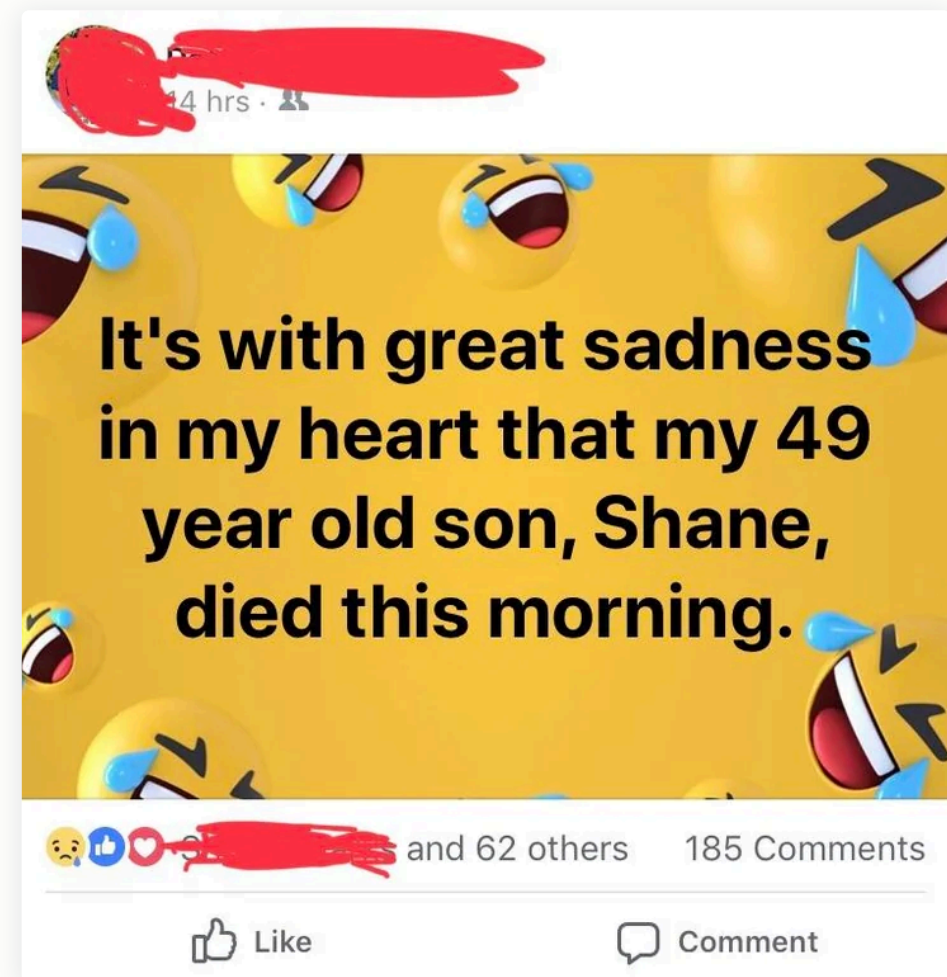
Symbols Carry Meanings That Change with Context

- **Symbols** — the gestures, objects, and words that form the basis of human communication
- The thumbs-up gesture, a gold star sticker, and the smiley face in an e-mail are all symbols
- Many symbols are deceptively simple yet rich in meaning, and they may not mean the same thing in every social context

Emoji Meaning Comes from the Message Around It

- A 😂 may express literal laughter, soften a sentence, fill a pause, or function like habitual punctuation
- In this post, news of a death and a laughing-emoji background collide, producing a meaning the writer almost certainly did not intend
- A 💀 can mean “that was so funny I died”; a 👍 can read as warm agreement, a quick acknowledgment, or an abrupt reply

A symbol has no fixed meaning outside its message, audience, and setting.



Thinking Critically: Communication as Cultural Capital

How can the way you communicate, verbally and nonverbally, be a form of cultural capital?

- Which accents, vocabularies, or greetings open doors in a job interview or a hospital ward?
- Which gestures or forms of address signal that someone “belongs”?
- Who had the chance to learn those codes early, and who is learning them now?

Norms and Sanctions

Every society encourages the behavior it approves of and discourages the behavior it does not. Norms set the standard; sanctions enforce it.

Norms Are Established Standards of Behavior

- “Wash your hands before dinner.” “Thou shalt not kill.” “Respect your elders.”
- **Norms** — the established standards of behavior maintained by a society
- For a norm to become significant, it must be widely shared and understood
- Application varies by context: moviegoers insist on silence during a serious film more than during a slapstick comedy or horror movie

Formal and Informal Norms

- **Formal norms** — generally written down; specify strict punishments for violators
- **Law** — “governmental social control”. Formal norms enforced by the state (Donald Black 1995)
- Laws are one example; parking restrictions and the rules of a football or basketball game are also formal norms
- **Informal norms** — generally understood but not precisely recorded, such as standards of proper dress; laughter is the likeliest response to a violation
- In Kuwaiti hospitality, immediately accepting an offered item can feel too eager; a polite refusal followed by the host’s insistence lets both sides display modesty and generosity

Mores and Folkways

- Norms are also classified by their relative importance to society
- **Mores** — norms deemed highly necessary to the welfare of a society, often because they embody its most cherished principles; violation brings severe penalties
- Kuwait, like other nation-states, has strong mores against murder, treason, and child abuse; these are also institutionalized as formal norms
- **Folkways** — norms governing everyday behavior; violation raises comparatively little concern, such as walking up a down escalator

Formal/informal asks whether the rule is written and punished. Mores/folkways asks how much society cares.

Sanctions Are Penalties and Rewards

- A driver uses the emergency lane to pass traffic. Someone throws a bottle onto the pavement. A graduate wears shorts to a bank interview.
- **Sanctions** — penalties **and rewards** for conduct concerning a social norm
- Positive sanctions: a pay raise, a medal, a word of gratitude, a pat on the back
- Negative sanctions: fines, threats, imprisonment, stares of contempt

Littering may be formally illegal in two societies but attract very different levels of public disapproval and enforcement. The written rule alone does not tell us the norm's strength.

Table 3–1: Norms and Sanctions

Norms	Positive sanctions	Negative sanctions
Formal	Salary bonus · testimonial dinner · medal · diploma	Demotion · firing from a job · jail sentence · expulsion
Informal	Smile · compliment · cheers	Frown · humiliation · bullying

- Sanctions attached to formal norms tend to be formal: the team is penalized 15 yards; the driver pays a fine
- Sanctions for informal norms vary: the candidate in shorts may lose the job, or be so brilliant that the attire is overlooked

Sanctions Reflect a Culture's Values and Priorities

- The entire fabric of norms and sanctions reflects a culture's values and priorities
- The most cherished values are the most heavily sanctioned; less critical matters carry light, informal sanctions
- During the coronavirus pandemic, people debated whether governments should sanction failure to comply with distancing and face-covering orders

Which behaviors in Kuwait carry the heaviest sanctions? What does that tell you about the values behind them?

Classify the Norm and Name the Sanction

For each scenario: **(1)** formal or informal norm? **(2)** mores or folkway? **(3)** one negative sanction for violating it, one positive sanction for honoring it.

1. Eating in public during daytime in Ramadan
2. Cutting the line at a supermarket
3. Running a red light
4. Arriving at a wedding in jeans and sneakers
5. Hosting a guest and offering nothing, not even water
6. Scrolling your phone while an elder speaks to you

Two questions settle most cases: *Did anyone write the rule down, with set penalties?* and *How deeply does society care?*

People Do Not Follow Norms in All Situations

- **Weak enforcement** invites evasion: drivers may use a phone at the wheel when they expect no camera or police officer
- Apparent violation can be **conformity to a group's norms**: friends may pressure a driver to speed because “everyone on this road does it”
- **Norms conflict**: stopping to let another car merge may honor courtesy but violate the impatient expectations of drivers behind you

Which traffic rules in Kuwait are strongly enforced by law, by other drivers, by both, or by neither?

Acceptance of Norms Changes with Social Conditions

- Acceptance of norms shifts as the political, economic, and social conditions of a culture change
- A rule that once seemed natural can become inconvenient, contested, or unacceptable when everyday conditions change
- In 2020, refusing a handshake shifted quickly from seeming unfriendly to signaling care; elbow greetings and greater distance temporarily became normal
- The behavior did not change meaning by itself. The surrounding social condition changed its meaning

The Same Action Can Follow One Norm and Violate Another

A lecture uses a QR code for attendance. An absent student asks a friend to send it. The class chat calls that “helping a friend”; the instructor calls it falsifying attendance.

- Which **formal norm** would the friend violate?
- Which **informal peer norm** might encourage the same action?
- What values collide: loyalty, fairness, honesty, compassion, or something else?
- Predict one sanction from the university and one from the peer group

People can conform to one group's norms while violating another group's rules.

Values

Values are the shared ideas of what is good and desirable that norms and sanctions exist to protect.

Values Are Collective Conceptions of the Good and Desirable

- **Values** — collective conceptions of what is considered good, desirable, and proper, or bad, undesirable, and improper, in a culture
- Values may be specific (honoring one's parents, owning a home) or general (health, love, democracy)
- Members of a society do not uniformly share its values; angry political debates show that much
- Values, norms, and sanctions connect: a culture that values marriage may prohibit adultery and make divorce difficult; one that values private property has stiff laws against theft
- A culture that values **public safety** requires seat belts and fines dangerous driving
- A university that values **learning and fairness** requires attendance, cites sources, and sanctions plagiarism

Values Differ Across Cultures: Private Tutoring in Japan and South Korea

- In Japan, young children spend long hours with private tutors preparing for selective-school entrance exams; the services carry no stigma and are highly valued
- In South Korea, people complain that “cram schools” give affluent students an unfair advantage; since **2008** the government has limited their hours and imposed fees
- Some say the policy lowered expectations and tried to make South Koreans “more American” (Mani 2018; Ramstad 2011; Ripley 2011)

Culture Wars and Shared Values

Culture wars turn disagreements over symbols, identity, and everyday rules into conflicts over what society should be.

Culture Wars Cross Borders Through Media and Institutions

- **Culture war** — the polarization of society over controversial cultural elements
- The conflict may concern the language used in schools, what people may wear in public institutions, who owns museum objects, or what online platforms permit
- A local dispute can become global when news, entertainment, brands, and social media carry the symbols across borders
- Calling it a culture war can clarify the value conflict, but it can also exaggerate two unified camps when opinions are more varied

Who benefits when a disagreement is described as a “war” rather than a debate?

Do Cultural Values Divide the World into Civilizations?

- Some scholars interpret international conflict as a **clash of civilizations** (Huntington 1993)
- The main idea: cultural and religious identities, rather than national or political loyalties, are becoming the prime source of international conflict
- Critics say that political interests, institutions, and inequality cannot be reduced to culture
- Speaking of a single “civilization” also disguises major differences within every large religious, national, or regional category (Said 2001)

Sociological Perspectives on Culture

Functionalists and conflict theorists agree that culture and society support each other. They disagree about why, and about who benefits.

Functionalists: Shared Values and Norms Provide Stability

- Social stability requires consensus and the support of society's members
- Strong central values and common norms provide that support
- A cultural trait or practice will persist if it performs functions that society seems to need or contributes to stability and consensus



Functionalists Ask What a Cultural Practice Does

- **Traffic rules** coordinate strangers who may never speak to one another
- **Shared calendars and timetables** let schools, workplaces, and families plan together
- **Hospitality rituals** build trust and define obligations between host and guest
- **Graduation ceremonies** mark a transition and reaffirm the value placed on education

A functionalist can also ask about dysfunctions: a practice may create solidarity for insiders while making participation harder for outsiders.

Conflict Theorists: Culture Maintains the Privileges of Powerful Groups

- A common culture may exist, but it serves to maintain the privileges of certain groups
- While protecting their self-interest, powerful groups may keep others in a subservient position
- **Dominant ideology** — the set of cultural beliefs and practices that helps to maintain powerful social, economic, and political interests
- First used by Georg Lukács (1923) and Antonio Gramsci (1929); in Marx's view, a capitalist society's dominant ideology serves the ruling class

It is rude to talk about how much money you make.

Hegemony and Culture Industry

- **Hegemony** — leadership maintained partly by winning consent, so one group's view of the world comes to feel natural or simply “common sense”
- Schools, media, workplaces, and other institutions can help reproduce dominant ideas about what is normal, legitimate, or desirable.
- **Culture industry** — described mass-produced entertainment that standardizes cultural goods and consumer desires
- We may appear to have enormous choice, while repeatedly encountering similar formats, stories, celebrities, and ideas
- A streaming service may offer thousands of titles while promoting the same formats, stars, and story structures

Can a Complex Society Have a Core Culture?

- A **core culture** would be a set of widely shared values and practices that helps coordinate social life
- Complex societies also contain regional, generational, occupational, religious, and digital subcultures
- Culture is not the same as nationality or language: two people may share both and still have very different cultural backgrounds
- Ann Swidler (1986): culture supplies a **tool kit** that people use to build different strategies of action—even when they disagree
- The useful question is not simply “one culture or many?” but which practices are widely shared, which are contested, and which institutions give some greater influence

Fiji Through Two Perspectives

Fiji: a rounded body was the ideal. Cable television arrived in 1995. Eating disorders appeared for the first time.

- **Functionalism question:** What function did the older body ideal serve, and what was destabilized?
- **Conflict question:** Whose interests could the imported ideal serve, and through which institution?

Which perspective explains more of what happened? Why?

Table 3–2: Sociological Perspectives on Culture

	Functionalist	Conflict	Interactionist
Norms	Reinforce societal standards	Reinforce patterns of dominance	Are maintained through face-to-face interaction
Values	Are collective conceptions of what is good	May perpetuate social inequality	Are defined and redefined through social interaction
Culture and society	Culture reflects a society's strong central values	Culture reflects a society's dominant ideology	A society's core culture is perpetuated through daily social interactions
Cultural variation	Subcultures serve the interests of subgroups	Countercultures question the dominant social order; ethnocentrism devalues groups	Customs and traditions are transmitted through intergroup contact and through the media

Shared Nationality Does Not Mean Identical Culture on Campus

Kuwait University students are overwhelmingly Kuwaiti. Does the campus still contain multiple subcultures?

- Compare majors, generations, clubs, friendship groups, online communities, schedules, styles of speech, and uses of campus space
- What seems shared across the university? What varies without being visible at first glance?
- Which perspective from Table 3-2 does your answer lean on?

Cultural Variation

Cultures adapt to their circumstances, and within one society smaller cultures form, oppose, and surprise each other.

Cultures Adapt to Climate, Technology, Population, and Geography

- Despite universals such as courtship and religion, great diversity exists among the world's cultures
- Inuit hunters in northern Canada, dressed in fur, share little with farmers in Southeast Asia dressed lightly for hot, humid rice paddies
- Cultures adapt to specific circumstances: climate, level of technology, population, and geography
- Within a single nation, segments of the population develop patterns that differ from the dominant society, a **culture within a culture**

Subcultures Share a Distinctive Pattern Within the Larger Society

- **Subculture** — a segment of society that shares a distinctive pattern of customs, rules, and traditions that differs from the pattern of the larger society
- Rodeo riders, residents of a retirement community, workers on an offshore oil rig
- Members participate in the dominant culture while engaging in unique and distinctive forms of behavior
- Many subcultures are characteristic of complex societies

Argot Marks Insiders from Outsiders

- **Argot** — specialized language that distinguishes a subculture from the wider society
- Parkour runners do *King Kong vaults* and *tic tacs* (Kidder 2012); vapers distinguish *substitutes* from *cloud chasers* (Tokle and Pedersen 2020)
- Argot lets insiders understand words with special meanings and creates patterns of communication outsiders cannot follow
- Interactionists emphasize that language and symbols let a subculture feel cohesive and maintain its identity

Name an argot you speak: in your major, your sport, your gaming group, or your family.

Gangs Can Develop Subcultures

- Some gangs develop their own roles, rules, slang, symbols, loyalty expectations, and sanctions
- A member may conform closely to the group's norms while violating laws or the wider society's mores
- Recruitment, crime, labeling, and social control return in the later chapter on deviance

What becomes visible when we ask, "Which norms are members following?" as well as "Which laws are they breaking?"

India's Call Centers Formed a Subculture of Virtual Migration

- Young Indian employees serving U.S. and European customers must be fluent in English and adopt Western values and the grueling U.S. work pace
- They live in **virtual migration**: not quite in India, not in the United States
- Days off come only on U.S. holidays such as Thanksgiving, not on Diwali; when they are free, no one else is
- They formed a tight-knit subculture of hard work, Western luxury goods, and shared contempt for the slow, often rude callers they serve (Krishnamurthy 2018)

Countercultures Deliberately Oppose Aspects of the Larger Culture

- **Counterculture** — a subculture that conspicuously and deliberately opposes certain aspects of the larger culture
- By the late 1960s, young Americans challenged materialism, favored sharing and environmental coexistence, and opposed the Vietnam War
- From 1976, British **punk** used music, DIY production, clothing, and provocation to reject polished mainstream youth culture
- Soviet **stilyagi** embraced jazz, bright fashion, slang, and public display against ideological conformity
- Countercultures often attract the young and can become catalysts for wider cultural change



U.S. 1960s • British punk • Soviet stilyagi

Culture Shock Can Be Mutual

- **Culture shock** — feeling disoriented, uncertain, out of place, or even fearful when immersed in an unfamiliar culture
- Visiting a Japanese home, you remove your shoes. Entering the bathroom, you see identical slippers and put on a pair. Your host reacts with horror: you have worn the toilet slippers into the living room (McLane 2013)
- In Kuwait, a guest may politely refuse an offer before accepting after the host insists. A visitor who says “yes” immediately may seem eager; a visitor who treats the first “no” as final may seem ungenerous
- A guest who does not shake the finjan may keep receiving coffee; the server is following the code, not ignoring the guest
- The visitor’s habits may shock the host as much as the host’s shock the visitor
- Customs that seem strange to us may be normal and proper elsewhere, and ours may look odd from there

Development of Culture around the World

Innovation creates new culture; diffusion carries it across borders; technology speeds both and leaves rules struggling to catch up.

Powerful Forces Link Us to Cultures Elsewhere

- Despite our preference for our own way of life, students may study Leo Tolstoy's novels, Pablo Picasso's art, or Nancy Meyer's films
- They may watch Korean dramas, Turkish series, Indian films, or follow social movements abroad through satellite TV and social media
- Two social processes make these links possible: **innovation** and **diffusion**

Innovation: Discovery and Invention

- **Innovation** — the process of introducing a new idea or object to a culture
- **Discovery** — making known or sharing the existence of an aspect of reality: the structure of DNA, a new moon of Saturn
- **Invention** — combining existing cultural items into a form that did not exist before: the bow and arrow, the automobile, television, Protestantism, democracy
- Sharing the new knowledge with others is a significant part of discovery

Name one culturally significant discovery and one invention from your own lifetime. How has each affected the culture you belong to?

Diffusion Spreads Cultural Items Between Societies

- **Diffusion** — the process by which a cultural item spreads from group to group or society to society
- People in Asia are discovering coffee; North Americans discovered sushi, now a supermarket item
- The move changed sushi: Americans treat it as take-out, while the authentic way is to sit at the bar and talk with the chef about the day's catch
- Diffusion travels through exploration, military conquest, missionary work, mass media, tourism, the Internet, and the fast-food restaurant

What in Kuwait arrived through diffusion—and how did people here change it? Remember **سيدا، دريشة، جوتي، بنجر**: diffusion is not only sushi and coffee. You are speaking it.

A Smartphone Makes the Global Village Concrete

- Its minerals, components, assembly, software, financing, and marketing may connect workers and firms across several countries
- The same device carries Korean music, Turkish dramas, Arabic podcasts, U.S. platforms, and messages from family in Kuwait
- Globalization does not erase the local: users select, translate, remix, and regulate what arrives
- It also distributes gains and risks unevenly, which is why functionalists and conflict theorists ask different questions about the same phone

Let's Discuss: How Does Globalization Affect You?

- How are you affected by globalization? Which aspects do you find advantageous, and which objectionable?
- How would you feel if the customs you grew up with were replaced by another country's culture or values?
- How might you try to protect your culture?

Ritzer's McDonaldization of Society

- **McDonaldization of society** — George Ritzer's extension of Weber's theory of rationalization: fast-food principles organize more and more areas of life
- Four dimensions: **efficiency, calculability, predictability, and control**
- The attraction is a fast, measurable, familiar result; the cost can be rigid routines and the "**irrationality of rationality**"



IKEA is Ritzer's own extended example: the route, self-service warehouse, flat packs, and standardized instructions shift work to customers while making the experience predictable.

McDonald's Had to Localize Its Menus

- Until 2001, McDonald's ran overseas operations from headquarters in suburban Chicago
- After false starts, executives relied on local advice to develop menus and marketing
- Japan, more than 3,700 restaurants: the **Mega Tamago Burger** (beef, bacon, fried egg); India: the vegetarian **McAloo Tikki** potato burger, and vegetarian-only restaurants since 2013 (Gasparro and Jargon 2012; Ritzer 2018)

Which global brands in Kuwait have changed their menus, hours, or marketing to fit local culture? Is that diffusion, McDonaldization, or both?

Technology Accelerates Diffusion and Transmits Culture

- **Technology** — “cultural information about the ways in which the material resources of the environment may be used to satisfy human needs and desires” (Nolan and Lenski 2015)
- New developments no longer wait for journals; press conferences carried on the Internet announce them
- Platforms and recommendation systems make some languages and cultural products much more visible than others
- The English language and North American culture have disproportionate online visibility, steering the direction of diffusion
- Translation, subtitles, and short-form video accelerate diffusion, but access and visibility remain uneven

Language and Algorithms Create Partly Separate Online Worlds

A Malayalam-speaking creator documents daily life in Kuwait for thousands of viewers. An Arabic-speaking resident may never see the channel.

- The Internet is shared infrastructure, but it is not one shared cultural experience
- Language, location, searches, follows, and watch history help recommendation systems decide what becomes visible
- People in the same city can therefore inhabit different media worlds and know different versions of life around them
- Translation can cross a language boundary—but first the content has to reach someone who wants to translate it

Ogburn: Material and Nonmaterial Culture

- William F. Ogburn (1922) distinguished two elements of culture
- **Material culture** — the physical or technological aspects of daily life: food, houses, factories, raw materials
- **Nonmaterial culture** — ways of using material objects, plus customs, beliefs, philosophies, governments, and patterns of communication
- A road contains both: cars, lanes, and signals are material; “red means stop,” where pedestrians look, and driver etiquette are nonmaterial
- Nonmaterial culture is generally **more resistant to change** than material culture

Culture Lag: When Nonmaterial Culture Struggles to Catch Up

- **Culture lag** — the period of maladjustment when the nonmaterial culture is still struggling to adapt to new material conditions
- In 2010, manufacturers introduced electronic cigarettes; airlines, which ban smoking, and the Food and Drug Administration scrambled to respond (Kesmodel and Yadron 2010)

Name a culture lag you live inside. Which technology reached your life before the rules for it did?

Multilingual Life

Kuwait's Daily Life Uses Several Language Repertoires

- Formal Arabic, Kuwaiti Arabic, English, and many migrant languages meet in classrooms, hospitals, shops, homes, and workplaces
- **Bilingualism** uses two languages in a setting and treats both as legitimate; **multilingualism** extends that question beyond two
- People also **code-switch**. They move between languages or varieties as the audience, topic, and setting change
- The sociological question is not only which languages people know, but which variety carries authority in each institution

Foreigner-Directed Arabic and Gulf Pidgin Arabic Are Not the Same

- **Foreigner-directed Arabic**, also called Arabic Foreigner Talk (AFT), is when an Arabic speaker adjusts or simplifies how they speak for someone they think has limited Arabic
- **Gulf Pidgin Arabic (GPA)** developed when people with different first languages repeatedly needed a shared way to communicate in Gulf workplaces and households
- The difference: AFT is one speaker adjusting their Arabic in a conversation; GPA is a shared way of speaking that grows through repeated contact across a community (Dashti 2013; Salem 2013; Avram 2014)
- Calling either one merely “broken Arabic” hides the adaptive work speakers do to communicate

Three Perspectives Ask Different Questions About Multilingualism

- **Functionalism:** How does a shared language coordinate schools, hospitals, and workplaces? Where are interpreters or common terms necessary?
- **Conflict:** Who decides which language counts as professional or legitimate? Who bears the cost of adapting?
- **Interactionism:** How do a word choice, accent, greeting, or switch into English change the meaning of a face-to-face encounter?

Where in Kuwait do you hear people change their Arabic because of who is listening?
What does the change accomplish?

Initiating Policy: Nations Vary in Their Tolerance for Many Languages

- **China** extends Mandarin instruction in Tibet from high school down into elementary schools
- **Singapore** makes English the medium of instruction but lets students study their mother tongue: Chinese, Malay, or Tamil
- **Québec**: the French-speaking Québécois are 83 percent of the province but 25 percent of Canada; a 1978 law mandated French-language schooling
- In the 1995 referendum, Québec voted to remain in Canada by only **50.5 percent**; language both unifies and divides this nation of 37 million

Reading Everyday Life as Culture

The immigrant's experience, Schaefer writes, is about learning a whole new culture. So is the sociologist's.

Before You Leave

- Culture is the totality of learned, socially transmitted customs, knowledge, material objects, and behavior. It feels like nature because you learned it so early
- Ethnocentrism judges other cultures by our standards; cultural relativism understands them from inside, without surrendering judgment
- Norms set standards, sanctions enforce them, and values explain why some norms are guarded so fiercely
- Functionalists see culture as shared stability; conflict theorists ask whose interests a dominant ideology serves
- Culture is plural (subcultures, countercultures) and always moving (innovation, diffusion, culture lag)

Next: Chapter 4, Socialization. How did you learn all of this in the first place?